

Step-by-step reintroduction protocol for suddenly aggressive cats based on Jackson Galaxy methods - with troubleshooting for redirected aggression triggers — Action Checklist

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SEPARATE CATS IMMEDIATELY

- ☐ **Separate Cats Immediately:** Choose two zones on opposite ends of your home and move each cat to their own zone right now, because every encounter during high-arousal states extends the recovery timeline and makes reintroduction harder.
- ☐ **Set Up Complete Zones:** Equip each zone with a litterbox, food and water stations, a resting spot, and hiding places so cats feel safe, because stressed cats need their basic needs met without encountering the other cat.
- ☐ **Block Visual Access:** Close doors between zones or cover baby gates with blankets to prevent all visual contact between cats, because seeing each other keeps arousal levels spiked and prevents the 72-hour neurochemistry reset.
- ☐ **Commit to 72-Hour Separation:** Set a timer and do not allow any cat-to-cat contact until it goes off, no matter how calm they seem, because feline aggression responses require at least three days for their neurochemistry to normalize.

DIAGNOSE THE TRIGGER

- ☐ **Identify the Specific Aggression Type:** Determine whether you are dealing with status, fear-based, territorial, or redirected aggression by answering the diagnostic questions in writing, because the type determines your recovery timeline and intervention strategy.
 - ☐ **Look for the Redirected Aggression Trigger:** Investigate what caused the initial arousal spike, such as an outdoor cat, loud noise, or perceived threat, because redirected aggression is the most common cause of sudden relationship collapse in previously peaceful cats.
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- ☐ **Place the More Stressed Cat in the Quieter Zone:** Put the cat showing higher stress responses in the area with fewer foot traffic and more hiding spots, because equalizing their emotional security reduces the likelihood of continued defensive aggression.
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- ☐ **Document the Timeline in Writing:** Record exactly when the aggression started, what happened that day, and any environmental changes, because written documentation helps you identify patterns that aren't obvious in the moment.

FOLLOW THE REINTRODUCTION PROTOCOL

- ☐ **Follow the Week-by-Week Protocol:** Move through the structured phases from full separation to supervised proximity to full coexistence, because jumping ahead risks resetting the progress and extending the total recovery time.
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- ☐ **Use Advance-or-Pause Checkpoints:** Before moving to the next phase, assess whether both cats show calm body language and relaxed behavior, because recovery is not linear and cats will signal when they are genuinely ready.
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- ☐ **Schedule Weekly Reintroduction Check-Ins:** Mark your calendar for regular assessments of progress or setbacks, because consistent monitoring allows you to adjust the protocol before small problems become major setbacks.
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- ☐ **Recognize When to Accept Management as Success:** Understand that either a rebuilt relationship or a sustainable management plan counts as success, because the goal is peaceful multi-cat coexistence under the same roof, not perfection.
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Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.